Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

North
♠ K 8 2
♥ 6 4
♦ Q J 9 8 6
♣ A 7 6

West
♠ Q 7 5
♥ Q J 10 8 5 2
♦ A 3
♣ Q 5

N
W E
S

East
♠ 10 9 6 3
♥ 9 3
♦ K 5
♣ 10 9 8 4 2

South
♠ A J 4
♥ A K 7
♦ 10 7 4 2
♣ K J 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♥	3♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

South plays 3NT. As expected, West attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if East holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If West holds both the ♦A and ♦K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦A and ♦K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on East having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If West started with 6 ♥s then East will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up East has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when West wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

On the other hand, if West takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when East takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if West had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure East wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

North
♠ K 5
♥ J 7 5 3
♦ Q 6 2
♣ 8 5 4 2

West
♠ Q 10 8 3 2
♥ Q 9 6
♦ 8
♣ 10 9 7 3

N
W E
S

East
♠ A 7 4
♥ K 10 4 2
♦ J 9 7 4
♣ Q J

South
♠ J 9 6
♥ A 8
♦ A K 10 5 3
♣ A K 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. East plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. West plays the ♠2 on this trick.

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that West can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If West has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if East has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

Did you like that "play your cards right" quip? First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. West discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and East's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.